



Chapter Ten

Religion in the New Millennium

Study the painting and answer the following questions:

1. What appears to be the central message or theme of this illustration? Explain.
2. How do the circle and the fire serve to promote the message of the illustration? Be specific.
3. Identify the symbols that surround the image.

Introduction

Throughout history, religions have clashed and competed against each other. For centuries, Catholics and Protestants fought terrible wars in Europe. These religious conflicts continue today in various parts of the world. Northern Ireland has long been embroiled in a deadly struggle between Catholics and Protestants, while the Middle East continues to witness brutal conflicts among Muslims, Jews, and Christians.

However, in the last few decades the world has observed the development of a growing interfaith movement in which members of many faiths are engaged in respectful and tolerant communication. This dialogue is designed to promote harmony and understanding among different religions rather than division and conflict. This sentiment can be seen in the illustration on the opposite page, which was designed by a Sikh community in New Mexico.

Learning Goals

At the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- demonstrate an understanding of religious pluralism as a defining characteristic of Canadian society
- identify the diverse religions represented in Canada and analyse how the high degree of religious pluralism in the population is reflected in Canadian society and culture
- explain how the religious impulse can be expressed outside formal religion
- identify some areas in which relationships between people of different beliefs, traditions, and practices can create conflict
- explain the concepts of ecumenism and interfaith dialogue
- investigate the origins of the World's Parliament of Religions and analyze the implications of its recently published statements
- demonstrate an understanding of different belief systems, e.g., humanism
- demonstrate an understanding of the term *fundamentalist*
- analyze demographic data to predict religious change in society
- compile a demographic study of the various religions within your community



Canadians are fortunate in that we live in an environment of the various faith traditions of the world.



THE NEW CENTURY— YOUR CENTURY

In spite of the wonders of new technology and the triumphs of science, it is clear that humankind still needs and wants a sense of religion. Indeed, to some observers, the technological age has spurred an increased interest in a broad range of spiritual and faith traditions. Canada is uniquely positioned to participate in this new age because its multicultural society includes active, well-established communities with diverse religious practices. The future of religion will likely feature some of the themes presented in this chapter.

Religious Extremism

Meeting the challenges of the twenty-first century is one of the objectives of most faiths. Some people have firmly accepted the interfaith path and are keen on sharing information and ideas with members of different religions. However, there are some practitioners of religion who do not approve of this kind of exchange. They propose a more fundamental view of their faith that stresses traditional practices and beliefs. These **fundamentalists** fear that too much change will lead to a great dilution of their faith and a weakening of their values and practices. They sometimes demand a more literal and thus narrower interpretation of their scriptures.

One challenge of this century is **religious extremism**. Religious extremists move far beyond fundamentalists in their interpretation of their faith. They

are prepared to take violent action to defend their views and are willing to attack those who they deem enemies. At times, religious extremists may also try to spread their views across borders. In some countries, they have become politically active and attempt to use the power of the state to impose their beliefs on their fellow citizens. The Taliban in Afghanistan (Figure 10.1) are an example.

As the world changes ever more quickly and becomes increasingly multicultural, some people may choose the path of religious extremism to preserve what they feel is the truth. Most observers recognize that all major religions suffer from groups of extremists who do not fairly represent the spirit or teachings of their faith. In the twenty-first century, perhaps you will have a chance to witness the victory of tolerance and understanding over ignorance and prejudice.



Figure 10.1

In March 2001, the extremist Taliban government of Afghanistan ordered the destruction of this 1500-year-old Buddha statue in Bamiyan. Although Muslim, the Taliban are regarded as extremists by most Muslims and are not representative of Islam, which is respectful of other religious traditions.

Skill Path **Demographic Study**

Canada is a very multicultural and diverse country undergoing rapid changes in population. Canadians need some way to track and even predict these changes in order to understand the present and plan for the future. The study of population statistics is called demography.

Demographic data refers to facts and figures regarding population, such as age, gender, and household income. The goal of the demographer is to measure past and forecast future changes in population. Demographic researchers often collect data through methods such as surveys, questionnaires, and interviews. Sometimes they use the sampling method, which relies on a sample of the population to collect information.

As in all research, it is essential to clearly define the study group. For example, if the study group in question is the percentage of Canadians who attend religious services regularly, the researcher must clearly define the characteristics of that group before commencing his or her research. These characteristics essentially define the type of data to be collected. Frequency of occurrence (number of same responses) is generally communicated when analyzing the data through percentages rather than numbers. For example, the researcher may discover that 35 per cent of Canadians attend religious services regularly.

In order to draw conclusions about change in population, the researcher examines two factors: heads and events. The counting of "heads" refers to the population census, a common source for data. Births, deaths, and marriages might constitute important events that demographers count.

Population Census

A country's main source of information about its population comes from the population census. A census is a survey, which is taken in Canada every five years. For over 300 years, the census in Canada has provided a clear picture of Canadians, and the cities, towns, and villages in which we live. Statistics Canada, our national statistics agency, uses the data that it collects to produce statistical tables and reports. This information is available to researchers employed by communities, businesses, and governments for program development in the areas of day care, public transport, education, etc.

The questions asked in a typical Canadian census questionnaire relate to geographic, family, personal, cultural, and economic characteristics. The questionnaire might include questions about the following:

- Address
- Name
- Gender
- Age
- Marital Status
- Number of people living at residence, and their relationships to each other
- Language spoken
- Religion

The goal of the population census is to count heads as well as to identify household or family groupings. This information is particularly crucial to all those interested in assessing consumer demands.

Conducting a Survey for Demographic Research

Conducting a survey for demographic research involves the collection and analysis of data that relate to the opinions and habits of a population.

For example: The percentage of Canadians that attend religious services regularly.

In designing the survey, follow the helpful hints below.

- Choose your audience carefully.
- Decide how to carry out the survey: in person, through mail, e-mail, telephone, or Internet site.
- Try to guarantee the anonymity of your respondents.
- Compose simple questions that can be answered quickly. You may wish to create a multiple choice, yes/no, or rank-in-order survey.

*Sample multiple choice question:
Circle the appropriate answer below.
On average, I attend religious services*

- a) once a week.*
- b) once a month.*
- c) three to five times a year.*
- d) one to two times a year.*
- e) I never attend religious services.*

Before conducting the actual survey, do a test-run with a small group of people. Ask respondents to complete the survey. If conducting a survey with a large group, keep a record of all the completed surveys and store them carefully in a file. If conducting a sampling, work quickly and try to supervise the survey.

Record the results on a large tally sheet. Use percentages to present your results. When data are expressed using percentages or proportions of the total population, the researcher can quickly grasp the frequency indication and more readily compare the frequency of one group with a second group. Tables and charts are often used to represent findings in a demographic study.

Practise It!

1. Conduct a demographic survey to find out the religious affiliation of the students in your school or your class. Design and conduct your survey. Analyze your data and present your findings in percentages.

2. Refer to the Population by Religion information on the Statistics Canada Web site (below) from the last two censuses. What changes do you see in Canada's population in terms of religious composition? What changes, or trends, are likely in the future?

Visit the Statistics Canada web site at www.statisticscanada.ca.

Humanism

Figure 10.2

Organizations like Greenpeace are concerned about the destruction of the environment. Can you identify other organizations with the same concern?



Many people are concerned with living a good life, being ethical, and nurturing their fellow human beings. They sense an order and a rhythm to life but do not consider themselves to be religious. In fact, they may doubt or deny the existence of God, an eternal soul, or the concept of an afterlife. People who place their emphasis and concerns on humanity itself are adherents of a philosophy called **humanism**.

Humanism is a philosophy that emphasizes human welfare and dignity and is based on the belief that human beings alone are responsible for their fate. It was largely born in the exuberance of the Renaissance—a time that saw renewed interest in the arts and knowledge of the Greeks and Romans. While humanism originally existed alongside traditional religious beliefs, it became more and more opposed to official religious doctrine, superstition, and ritual. Immanuel

Kant (1724-1804), a German philosopher, argued that moral law was written on the heart of each person and that religion was not essential as a source of moral direction.

In Canada, contemporary humanists are concerned with many things, including human rights, equality, global issues, and racism. Increasingly, humanists are concerned about how our materialistic society is destroying the planet in pursuit of economic expansion and excess (see Figure 10.2). Canadian humanists are often in the forefront of issues relating to the Canadian Charter of Rights and Freedoms.

More recently, humanists and followers of religion have come to see the commonality of their concerns and are less focussed on their divisions and historical struggles. After all, the desire to lead a good and moral life and the urge to make the world a better and happier place appeals to almost everybody.

The Interfaith Age

We live in an era of great communication and dialogue within and among the world's religions. **Ecumenism** identifies the movement of denominations within Christianity to work more closely together and to foster a spirit of unity. There exists an even broader desire to reach out to other faiths. Although much of the history of the world has shown tremendous rivalry, competition, and even violence among peoples of differing faiths, there has been a growing movement based on **interfaith dialogue**, which stresses comparison and communication

Web Quest

For more information about humanism and some of the most pressing humanist concerns, visit the following Web sites:

www.humaniststudies.org

www.canada.humanists.net

rather than competition. Because Canada is growing increasingly multicultural and multi-religious, it is natural that our country should be in the forefront of the interfaith movement (Figure 10.3).

The growth of this movement does not signal that the world's religions are merging or abandoning their unique identities, but it does mean that the search for dialogue and understanding is on-going. There are undoubtedly some commonalities among many religions, however there is clearly a rich diversity as well. This diversity is recognized and accepted in the spirit of tolerance and respect. Religious pluralism is a defining characteristic of Canadian society and is increasingly a global development as well.

The World's Parliament of Religions

In 1893, a singular event took place in the American city of Chicago. At a time when religious competition and rivalry was still very intense, a group of religious leaders from radically different faith traditions met to foster peace and harmony among their followers. It was the first ground-breaking interfaith meeting of representatives from the great Eastern and Western faith traditions. While this first meeting resulted in a certain amount of tension and attempts to demonstrate superiority, the spirit of true interfaith dialogue and tolerance was born. For some, it was the remarks and spirit of the great Hindu teacher, Swami Vivekananda that set in motion a new era among the world's religions. He spoke the following words:

The Christian is not to become a Hindu or a Buddhist, nor a Hindu or a Buddhist become a Christian. But each must assimilate the spirit of the others and yet preserve his individuality and grow according to his own law of growth.



Just as the twentieth century was coming to an end, a second **World's Parliament of Religions** was held in Chicago, in 1993.

In 1999, the third World's Parliament of Religions was convened in Capetown, South Africa, where attendees heard passionate addresses by luminaries such as Nelson Mandela and the Dalai Lama. Plans are being developed to hold another World's Parliament of Religions in 2004 to further the pace and scope of interfaith co-operation.

Figure 10.3

Interfaith discussions, like this one in Scarborough, Ontario, are more and more common across Canada. Why is Canada at the forefront of the interfaith movement?

Community Study

Scarboro Missions Interfaith Desk



Figure 10.4

Interfaith Desk was involved in the

Golden Rule Poster, which features scripture passages and symbols of thirteen world religions.

With the migration of people, more regions of the world are becoming increasingly multicultural and multi-religious resulting in an encounter of religions that is new in history. At the same time, the great faiths of the world are talking to one another in a way that is innovative, challenging, and exciting.

The Catholic Church has asked its members to join in this interfaith conversation.

Through its Interfaith Desk, Scarboro Missions works to bring together people of various faiths, and to promote harmony among religions, cultures, and races. Founded in 1918 by Monsignor John Mary Fraser for work in China, Scarboro Missions is now present in countries throughout Asia, Africa, Latin America, and the Caribbean, as well as in Canada. Today, Christian missions are committed to interfaith dialogue, cross-cultural encounters, and social justice in Canada as well as abroad. Scarboro Missions' priests and laity are responding enthusiastically to this challenge.

Scarboro Missions sponsored its first interfaith event in 1995 in which members of eight world religions were invited to comment on Gandhi's philosophy of non-violence from the perspective of their religions. Working with representatives of

other faith traditions, the Interfaith Desk continues to sponsor and participate in several interfaith events in the Greater Toronto Area, around such themes as non-violence, ecology, and unity.

Many of these events are hosted by other religions at their place of worship, such as at a Baha'i centre, Sikh gurdwara, or Jain temple. The events usually involve observing the worship ceremony of the host faith and sharing a common meal after a day of interaction and dialogue. The Scarboro Interfaith Desk is particularly active with high-school students and teachers, and often organizes reflection days when students can meet with representatives of several world religions.

The Interfaith Desk has been recognized for its work and presented with a number of awards, including the Racial Harmony Award presented by the Community and Race Relations Committee of Toronto East. It has published several interfaith articles in its magazine, *Scarboro Missions*.

"Indeed, religious pluralism has proven to be one of the most extraordinary developments of the 20th century."

Paul McKenna (member of Interfaith Committee)

QUESTIONS

1. What are the central goals and activities of the Scarboro Missions Interfaith Desk?
2. Would you be interested in meeting members of other faiths and sharing a communal meal? Explain.

Sacred Text

In spite of the different origins and histories of the world's faiths, there is an apparent common thread that unites all believers. Once one ventures beyond the rich diversity of clothing, language, skin colour, ethnicity, religious practice, and hours of worship, he or she often finds a deeper commonality and unity of religious expression. The following are quotations from various faiths:

Confucianism

"Is there one word that sums up the basis of all good conduct? Surely it is the word loving kindness. Do not do unto others what you would not have done unto yourself."

-Confucius, Analects 15, 23

Buddhism

"Hurt not others in ways that you yourself would find hurtful."

-Udana-Varga 5.18

Christianity

"In everything, do unto others as you would have them do unto you"

-Jesus, Matthew 7:12

Aboriginal Spirituality

"We are as much as we keep the earth alive."

-Chief Dan George

Islam

"Not one of you truly believes until you wish for others what you wish for yourself."

-Muhammad, Hadith

Hinduism

"This is the sum of duty: do not do unto others what would cause pain unto you."

-Mahabharata 5:1517

Jainism

"One should treat all creatures in the world as one would like to be treated."

-Mahavira

Zoroastrianism

"That nature alone is good which refrains from doing unto another whatsoever is not good for itself."

-Dadistan-i-Dinik, 94:5

Judaism

"What is hateful to you do not do unto your neighbour. That is the entire law; all the rest is commentary."

-Hillel, Talmud-Shabbath 31a

Taoism

"Regard your neighbours gain as your own gain, regard your neighbours loss as your own loss."

-T'ai Shang Kan Ying P'ien, pp. 213-218

Sikhism

"I am a stranger to no one; and no one is a stranger to me. Indeed I am a friend to all."

-Guru Granth Sahib, p. 1299

Bahá'í

"He should not wish for others that which he doth not wish for himself, nor promise that which he doth not fulfill."

-Tablets of Bahá'u'lláh, 71

QUESTIONS

1. What appears to be the common theme that runs through most of these quotations?
2. Which quotations do you find most inspiring? Why?

Web Quest

Bahá'u'lláh, founder of the Bahá'í faith, taught that all the great religions of the world are one in their essential message of love.

To learn more about the Bahá'í faith, visit the Canadian Web site:
www.ca.bahai.org

Your Personal Journey

As you finish this book, you can take some pride in knowing that you have been introduced to numerous religious faiths, principles, and practices that may offer you some guidance and information for your very own spiritual journey through life. As a Canadian, you have access to a broad range of religious experiences within the boundaries of your country. Your neighbours and classmates are living proof of the religious diversity that surrounds you. Canada's laws and traditions protect and enhance religious expression, so you are free to grow and develop as a human being.

Hopefully, you have become more knowledgeable and tolerant of different approaches to life. Perhaps you understand your fellow Canadians a bit better and understand how enrich-

ing it can be to live and participate in such a multicultural society. Keep in mind that the completion of this book is really only the start of your personal exploration of life and its challenges. The authors of this text hope that some of the rich wisdom presented in this book will guide and inspire your personal spiritual evolution.

*No human life together
Without a world ethic for the
nations*

*No peace among the nations
Without peace among the religions*

*No peace among the religions
Without dialogue among the
religions*

-Hans Küng, Swiss Theologian

Figure 10.5

Young Canadians can pursue their personal spiritual journey in a nation rich in cultural and religious diversity. What faiths have made the greatest impression on you? Why?



Activities

Check Your Understanding

1. What are fundamentalists? How do they differ from religious extremists?
2. What is the appeal of humanism in today's world?
3. What is the meaning of the phrase "The Interfaith Age"?
4. What is the goal of the World's Parliament of Religions?
5. What are the most likely themes of religion in the new century?

Think and Communicate

6. Working in small groups, respond to the following question: What are the three most important things that you have learned from your study of some of the world's religions? Why?
7. Visit this Web site on the World's Parliament of Religions to analyze and report on one of the documents published by this organization.
www.nycinterfaith.org/parliament.htm

8. Working in small groups, create and complete a graphic organizer on the religions that you have studied this year. Decide on at least six comparative criteria, for example, country of origin, symbols, and basic beliefs, and then complete your organizer. Be prepared to present your organizer to your peers.

9. Briefly describe where you are on your personal journey at this point in your life.

Apply Your Learning

10. Review the many symbols and icons presented in this book and design a suitable symbol for the unity of the world's faiths. Prepare a brief written statement explaining your design.
11. Working with other students, prepare an attractive guide or resource book on religious communities in your area. Include information on places and times of worship, community resources, spokespersons, activities, events, and maps, etc.

Glossary

ecumenism [eck YOU m'n ism]. The movement to bring all Christian denominations closer together and to foster mutual understanding.

fundamentalism. Strict maintenance of traditional teachings and practices of any religion.

humanism. An outlook or system of thought that views humankind as the source of all value or meaning, rather than spiritual or religious matters.

interfaith dialogue. The movement among religious communities to communicate with each other openly and in the spirit of mutual understanding, respect, and tolerance.

religious extremism. The belief in extreme religious opinions and the advocacy of extreme action in support of those opinions.

World's Parliament of Religions. Meeting of representatives of the world's religions whose aim is mutual understanding, tolerance, and discussion of important issues.

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